Introduction to Marketing Final Project

Product: EverCrunch

MKTG 2209

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Executive Summary:

EverCrunch, developed by Arefin Mahmood, is an innovative cereal brand breaking into a new segment of the market: texture-based cereal. My patented, moisture resistant coating keeps my cereal crunchy for significantly longer, greatly improving the breakfast experience.

The product is targeted towards parents with kids aged 5-12, who often face rushed and chaotic morning routines. EverCrunch directly addresses a common frustration for these families, uneaten soggy cereal, by allowing kids to eat at their own pace without sacrificing texture. This benefit is immediately noticeable and requires no learning or behavior change from consumers, making it easy to integrate into their mornings.

EverCrunch's key competitive advantage lies in its unique positioning. While most cereal brands compete on taste, branding, or nutrition, EverCrunch differentiates itself by focusing on texture over time, an unmet need in the market. By owning this space, the brand establishes a clear, defensible identity that is both practical and memorable.

Through effective marketing across many platforms, targeted towards parents and kids, along with first purchase promotions, I will execute a successful product launch and build repeat customers. I will distribute my product widely both in store and online to make it very easy to buy for consumers. From this, I expect to profit in my first year and continue growing from there.

Introduction:

My product, EverCrunch, is a ready-to-eat breakfast cereal designed to solve one of the most common frustrations in the cereal category: sogginess. Unlike traditional cereals that quickly lose their texture once they sit in milk, EverCrunch is engineered with a thin, moisture-resistant coating that slows milk absorption and preserves the crunch for a significantly longer period of time. This coating will be made of a hydrophobic substance that is flavorless and safe to consume.

This innovative cereal allows consumers the chance to eat slower and have a more satisfying, satiating breakfast. For parents, this means less food gone to waste for being soggy and a more efficient morning. My product requires no change in consumer behavior, meaning it can easily fit into existing breakfast habits while improving the overall experience.

EverCrunch would be entering the highly competitive ready-to-eat cereal market, yet it would have a distinct advantage by focusing on texture over time rather than flavor or nutrition alone. This positions the product as both innovative and practical, and the benefit would be noticeable upon first use.

In addition to its functional design, my product EverCrunch would be elevated by its bright, engaging packaging and with its memorable brand name that reinforces its core promise. By combining innovation, convenience, and strong branding, I create a product that can stand out on the shelf and resonate with both parents and children. EverCrunch could redefine what a consumer expects from a cereal brand if launched successfully with a proper marketing strategy.

Marketing Environment (Opportunities & Threats):

American breakfast habits have shifted heavily toward speed and convenience. Families with young children often have rushed mornings, which makes grab-and-go or easy-prep foods like cereal a reliable staple. At the same time, parents are increasingly conscious of food waste and nutritional value-they want a product that's both practical and worth the money. The ready-to-eat cereal market is large and competitive, dominated by established brands that rely heavily on flavor variety, characters, and nutritional claims to drive purchases.

There's a clear gap in the market: no major cereal brand has made texture over time a central part of its identity. Most compete on taste or branding, which means the "stays crunchy longer" angle is entirely unclaimed. My product steps directly into that space. Busy family mornings create a genuine demand for cereal that holds up. Kids who eat slowly are a reality in most households, and a soggy, unfinished bowl is a frustration parents deal with regularly. Solving that problem in a way that requires zero behavior change from the consumer is a strong position to launch from.

The biggest challenge is the existing competitive landscape. Brands like Kellogg's, General Mills, and Post have massive marketing budgets, established shelf space, and deep consumer loyalty, breaking through as a new product requires a compelling and clearly communicated point of difference. Price sensitivity is also a real concern; families buying cereal weekly may hesitate at a slightly higher price point before experiencing the benefit firsthand, making first-time trials critical. There's also growing skepticism among health-conscious parents about processed or heavily engineered foods. A coating that "prevents sogginess" could raise

questions about what it's actually made of, so transparent ingredient labeling will be important from the start.

The product is built around a single, tangible, easily demonstrable benefit: it stays crunchy longer in milk. This kind of clear problem-solution story is rare in a category that mostly competes on subjective taste preferences. It gives me a focused value proposition that doesn't require a large marketing budget to explain. The benefit is immediately obvious the first time someone eats a bowl. The product also appeals to both decision-makers (parents) and end users (kids) without asking either group to compromise, which is a meaningful advantage in a household purchase context.

Segmentation, Targeting, and Market Size:

EverCrunch makes the most sense when segmented by demographic, behavioral, and psychographic traits. Demographically, the best fit is parents and guardians with children ages 5 to 12, since they are the ones making breakfast purchases for the household. Behaviorally, the product fits families who already buy cereal regularly and have children who eat slowly enough for sogginess to become a problem. Psychographically, EverCrunch is aimed at busy, convenience-focused families who want breakfast options that are easy, dependable, and less wasteful. This segmentation works well because it connects directly to the product's core benefit instead of trying to appeal to everyone in the cereal market.

The target market is parents buying breakfast foods for children ages 5 to 12. This is the right target because the problem EverCrunch solves is most relevant in households with young kids and rushed morning routines. Kids are also an important secondary market because their eating habits and preferences still influence what parents buy. In terms of market size, there are millions of U.S. families with children in this age range, which gives EverCrunch a large enough market to grow while still keeping a focused target. Instead of competing for every cereal buyer, the brand is concentrating on a specific group with a clear need, which makes the marketing approach stronger and more effective.

Consumer Buyer Behavior:

The consumer buying process for EverCrunch begins with problem recognition. Parents notice that their child's cereal gets soggy before it is finished, which creates frustration and can

also lead to wasted food. That problem pushes them into the information search and evaluation stages, where they compare cereal options based on taste, convenience, nutrition, price, and whether the product offers a meaningful benefit. EverCrunch has an advantage here because its value is simple and specific: it keeps cereal crunchy longer, which is easy for consumers to understand and test for themselves.

The purchase decision would usually happen in-store, where packaging, shelf placement, and price all play a role in getting a first-time trial. Parents are the main decision-makers because they care about value, practicality, and reducing waste, while kids influence the decision through taste, visual appeal, and overall eating experience. Post-purchase behavior is especially important for EverCrunch because if the cereal performs as promised, satisfaction should be high and repeat purchase becomes much more likely. That makes buyer behavior especially important for this product, since the long-term success of the brand depends on turning a common frustration into a repeatable reason to buy.

Positioning & Competitive Advantage:

For parents of children ages 5-12 who want a more enjoyable and less wasteful breakfast, EverCrunch is a ready-to-eat breakfast food that stays crunchy in milk far longer than traditional cereals, using a moisture-resistant coating that slows milk absorption from the very first bite. Most cereals in the market differentiate through flavor variety, colorful branding, or nutritional claims. What they don't address is texture over time-a problem every cereal-eating household knows but no brand has made central to its identity.

My competitive advantage is owning that space. I'm not trying to out-flavor Frosted Flakes or out-health a granola brand. I'm solving a specific, real problem that none of them are focused on. That gives me a defensible position: if consumers start associating "long-lasting crunch" with my brand, it becomes very hard for competitors to credibly copy that positioning without feeling like a reaction to me.

The focus on texture also aligns well with both audiences I'm marketing to. Parents care about not wasting food and not fighting with their kids about an unfinished bowl. Kids care about the experience of eating, and soggy cereal is objectively less fun. I satisfy both without asking either group to compromise.

Product:

The core benefit of the product would be that the cereal stays crunchy for longer. Additionally, what the customer will also be buying is the sensation of their food being fresher. Staying crunchy for longer also means that the cereal takes longer to chew, which slows down the eating experience and can be more satiating than if it were soggy.

The physical component of the product is that it has a specially engineered coating. This design is what allows the core product to exist. The packaging also serves a functional role by maintaining freshness and ensuring consistent quality from the first serving to the last.

Along with buying my product, the consumer would also be buying my customer satisfaction policy, where if you're not satisfied, you get your money back guaranteed

My cereal's Consumer-Goods Classification would be a convenience product because it's an item that consumers would buy weekly, quickly, and with minimal thought. Specifically, it would be a staple good because it's bought routinely.

Parents might pick my cereal so that in the mornings they can pour their kids' cereal for them in advance while they get ready for school. By the time the kids come down the stairs to eat, the cereal is still fresh and ready to eat. The cereal is also reasonably priced for its quality and signals that it is a 'justifiable premium' for what it offers.

The name of my cereal, EverCrunch, drives home the main idea of my core product, which is that it stays crunchier for longer. Additionally, it is catchy and easy to remember. The packaging of my brand will be bright and colorful with an easily identifiable mascot that will make it enticing for children and eye-catching to pull off of a shelf.

Pricing:

My Product will use a value-based pricing strategy, meaning I will price it based on value perceived, not strictly on costs or market prices. I will still have to factor in what it costs to produce the product and what other brands charge, but those will not be the primary factors. My cereal has the unique value of not getting soggy in milk, which prevents frustration in kids and parents. Because this benefit improves the breakfast experience and reduces food waste, customers would be willing to pay a little more than they would for traditional cereals.

In addition to perceived value, it is important to factor development costs into pricing. The development of the non-soggy coating creates fixed costs that budget brands do not have.

Because of this, I can't sell it at a competitive price with the discount brands. Consequently, it would not make sense to use a competitive price strategy. Discount cereals can be around $2-3 per box, and it would not be feasible to be profitable while delivering a quality product at that price point. Instead, I will charge in the $5-6 range, putting it in the mid to upper price range for cereals. This positioning allows me to communicate high value while staying accessible to my target families. The most expensive cereals/granolas on the market are around $7-8, however, those are usually specialty health brands not targeted to families. By pricing slightly below premium prices, I find a balance between perceived value and affordability. From a customer perspective, my price communicates a "justifiable premium". When shopping, customers might hesitate slightly over the price, but they will also see that it's not the most expensive item on the shelf. The middle ground pricing will make them comfortable with buying it for the first time, and once they experience the long-lasting crunch, they will be more likely to become repeat customers.

I will also reinforce this value through promotion. Advertisements can highlight that the higher upfront cost actually saves money in the long run by reducing soggy, uneaten cereal that gets thrown out. This framing shifts the focus when making decisions from the price to the overall value and efficiency for parents.

Place/Distribution:

EverCrunch should use a mass distribution strategy because it is a convenience product that consumers expect to find easily during their normal grocery shopping routine. The product should be sold in grocery stores, supermarkets, and major big-box retailers, since these are the places where parents already shop for weekly household food items. This market coverage strategy fits the product well because EverCrunch is not meant to be exclusive or hard to find. Its value comes from fitting naturally into everyday breakfast habits, so broad availability is important.

The distribution channel would follow the standard path of manufacturer to distributor to retailer to customer. In this channel, distributors help move the product efficiently to a large number of stores, while retailers provide the shelf space and customer access needed for the product to compete. Strong shelf placement would also matter because EverCrunch would be entering a crowded cereal aisle with many established brands. By making the product widely

available and easy to notice, the place strategy supports trial, repeat purchase, and the brand's overall convenience-focused positioning.

Promotion (IMC Strategy):

My company will use an integrated marketing strategy, including both push and pull strategies, to attract parents and kids to the product. The marketing, across many platforms, will emphasize the unique value of not getting soggy, while catching customers' attention with interesting ads.

I will primarily rely on a pull strategy to create demand for the product so customers will intentionally seek it out in stores. For parents, I will use social media marketing on apps like Instagram and Facebook, where many parents are exposed to lifestyle content. I will collaborate with parent influencers who can make videos highlighting how the cereal makes their lives easier. This will appeal to the logical decision-making of parents. For kids, I will focus on fun, exciting ads, placed on children's YouTube channels and TV shows. In these ads, I can show kids eating my cereal and enjoying the crunch. I can also show contrast with sad kids eating soggy cereal to highlight how my cereal is better. By appealing directly to kids, I encourage them to ask their parents to purchase the product, reinforcing the pull strategy from another angle.

In addition to pull tactics, I will also use push strategies to help my product perform well in stores, especially when it first launches. This could include things like temporary discounts or coupons to encourage people to try it and feel more comfortable buying from a new brand. I will also use eye-catching in-store displays that highlight the unique crunchiness of the cereal. Packaging will also play a big role in this. The box will feature a fun, memorable character to appeal to kids and put a face to the brand. I will use an aquatic animal as the mascot to reiterate the idea of being able to stay in water for a long time. These in-store factors catch the attention of customers who aren't planning to buy this cereal when they go to the store, but it will convince them.

Overall, this IMC strategy combines traditional, digital, and in store marketing to effectively reach both parents and children. I will push people to go to the store to buy my cereal, and once there, convince them that purchasing it is the right decision. By consistently emphasizing the cereal's unique benefit, my messaging will stay clear and focused across all

platforms. This is further supported by my tagline, “Crunch that lasts till the last bite,” which simply and memorably reinforces my product's core value. These promotional efforts will support a successful product launch and long-term brand growth.

Financials (Basic Estimates):

I plan to price the product at approximately $5.50 per box, which sits in the mid-to-upper range of the cereal category and reflects the added value of the moisture-resistant coating. This price point keeps the product accessible to families while communicating a meaningful quality premium over budget brands.

Revenue projections (year 1)

For a rough first-year estimate, consider the following assumptions:

- Target retail accounts: 500 grocery and big-box store locations
- Average units sold per store per month: 30 boxes
- Price per unit (wholesale, ~55% of retail): ~$3.02

This yields an estimated year 1 gross revenue of approximately $543,600 (500 stores x 30 units x 12 months x $3.02).

These numbers are conservative and assume limited brand awareness at launch. As repeat purchases grow and distribution expands, revenue potential increases significantly.

Cost Category	Estimated Annual Cost
Production (ingredients, coating, packaging)	~$180,000
Marketing and promotion (launch campaign, in-store displays)	~$80,000
Distribution logistics	~$50,000
Total estimated costs	~$310,000

Based on the above:

- Gross revenue: ~$543,600
- Total costs: ~$310,000
- Estimated profit: ~$233,600

These are rough estimates intended to demonstrate that the concept can be profitable at a realistic scale. Production costs per unit will decrease as volume increases, improving margins over time. The primary cost driver unique to my product-the moisture-resistant coating- is offset by the premium pricing and the strong repeat purchase potential from a genuinely differentiated product.

Conclusion:

EverCrunch would be a great product to enter the cereal market since it addresses a simple yet widespread consumer complaint. By focusing on long-lasting crunch, which is a clear and differentiated value proposition, the brand is able to stand apart from competitors that primarily compete on taste, branding, or perceived health benefits.

My marketing strategy aligns closely with the needs and behaviors of the target market. EverCrunch cereal appeals to parents seeking convenience while also engaging children with an enjoyable eating experience. Each element of my marketing mix- product design, pricing, and distribution- work together to support the brand's positioning and encourage trial, adoption, and repeat purchases.

Financial projections further demonstrate that the concept is not only innovative but also viable, with strong potential for profitability as popularity and distribution grows. EverCrunch is well-positioned to meet the demand of consumers looking to simplify their daily cereal routine and reduce wasted soggy cereal, especially in today's age where the cost of groceries is becoming more expensive.

In conclusion, EverCrunch would be entering the market with a clear competitive advantage of prolonged crunchiness alongside a cohesive marketing strategy that would bring me right to my target market. With effective execution, it has the potential to establish a strong presence on the shelves and build brand loyalty among families.

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